



JKBOSE

🔥 2026 CLASS 11th 🔥

A PHOTOGRAPH

ENGLISH

LECTURE-1

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TOPICS TO BE COVERED

- 1** ... Complete poem (explanation)
- 2** ... Stanza wise Summary
- 3** ... MCqs (as per) stanza wise
- 4** ... Textual questions.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Shirley Toulson: was an English poet and writer, born in 1924. She is best known for her poem "A Photograph," which talks about memories, loss, and the passage of time. She wrote many poems and books about nature, walking, and ancient paths in Britain.

During World War II, she served in the army, and later studied English in London. She was also a journalist and took part in local politics. Shirley was married twice and had children. She passed away in 2018 at the age of 94. Her writing is remembered for its emotional depth and connection to history and landscape.



A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

The ^{picture} cardboard shows me how it was
 When the two girl cousins went paddling,
 Each one holding one of my mother's hands,
 And she the big girl — some twelve years or so.

Cardboard: photograph pasted on a hard thick Paper

Paddling: to walk in water that is not very deep

SUMMARY:

The poet looks at a photograph showing her mother as a young girl, about twelve years old, standing with her two cousins on the beach. The photograph is printed on cardboard and captures a moment from the past when they were enjoying their time paddling in the sea.



QUESTION

What does the cardboard in the poem refer to?

1 A painting



2 A photograph



3 A photo frame

4 A greeting card



QUESTION

How many girls were in the photograph?

1 One ✗

2 Two ↑

3 Three ✓

4 Four ↗



QUESTION

Where were the girls standing in the photograph?

1 At the beach ✓

2 On the road

3 At home

4 In a park



A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

All three stood still to smile through their hair. At the uncle with the camera. A sweet face, My mother's, that was before I was born. And the sea, which appears to have changed less. Washed their terribly transient feet.

Sea: Symbolises eternity and immortality

Transient feet: symbolises a short lived life of human beings

SUMMARY:

The girls posed smiling for the photo, their hair blown across their faces by the wind. The poet fondly remembers her mother's sweet face in the picture. The sea in the background seems unchanged with time, while the girls, especially her mother, have changed and grown older, emphasizing the fleeting nature of life.

QUESTION

Who clicked the photograph?

- 1 The poet ✗
- 2 Her uncle ✓
- 3 Her mother ✗
- 4 A stranger ✗



QUESTION

How is the poet connected to the photograph?

- 1 She is in it
- 2 Her friend is in it
- 3 Her mother is in it
- 4 Her teacher is in it



A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

20 to 30 years later
 Some twenty — thirty — years later She'd laugh at
 the ^{picture} snapshot. ("See Betty And Dolly," she'd say, "and
 look how ^{parents} they Dressed us for the beach.") The sea
 holiday. Was her past, mine is her laughter. Both
 wry With the laboured ease of loss.

Betty and dolly
 Cousins.

SUMMARY:

Years later, the poet's mother would look at the photograph and laugh, reminiscing about the beach holiday with her cousins, Betty and Dolly. For the mother, the photo represents a moment from her past. For the poet, her mother's laughter while remembering the past is now a memory, and both feel the pain of loss in their own ways.

QUESTION

What did the poet's mother feel when she saw the photograph?

- 1 Angry
- 2 Sad ✓
- 3 Embarrassed
- 4 Amused



QUESTION

Who were Betty and Dolly?

1 Poet's sisters ✗

2 Cousins of poet's mother

3 Poet's sisters ✗

4 The poet's aunts



QUESTION

What is meant by “The sea holiday was her past, mine is her laughter”?

- 1 Both enjoy the same holiday ✗
- 2 The poet is sad about her past ✗
- 3 The poet and her mother went to the sea ✗
- 4 ✓ The poet's mother remembers her childhood, the poet remembers her mother's laughter



A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Now she has been dead nearly as many years. As that girl lived. And of this ^{situation} circumstance, There is nothing to say at all, Its silence silences.

12 years ago
She died

***Of this circumstance:** Death of Poetess's mother
Sense of loss is quite painful to bear*

SUMMARY:

The poet reflects on her mother's death, noting that she has been gone for almost as many years as she had lived. The pain of her absence is profound, leaving the poet speechless. The final line, "Its silence silences," captures the deep, wordless grief that comes with such a loss.

QUESTION

What does “its silence silences me” mean?

1 The poet is overwhelmed by grief

2 The poet is speechless with joy ✕

3 The poet does not like silence ✕

4 The poet wants to talk †



QUESTION

What is the tone of the stanza?



1 Humorous

2 Mournful and reflective ✓

3 Joyful

4 Indifferent



QUESTION

What does the poet express through this stanza?

1 Happiness and fun

2 Loss and silence

3 Anger and regret

4 Friendship and bonding



A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Imagery

The poet creates vivid pictures in the reader's mind.

Example:

"Each one holding one of my mother's hands" → visual imagery

This helps visualize the scene at the beach.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Alliteration

Repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words.

Example:

“Stood still to smile through their hair”

Repetition of the (s) sound adds rhythm and softness.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Enjambment

When a sentence or phrase runs over from one line to the next without a pause.

Example:

"The sea holiday/Was her past, mine is her laughter.

"It creates a natural flow and emphasizes meaning.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Oxymoron

A combination of contradictory terms.

Example:

“Laboured ease of loss”

Describes how remembering the past brings both comfort and pain.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Personification

Giving human qualities to non-human things.

Example:

"Its silence silences.

"Silence is described as having the power to silence the poet.

A Photograph *Shirley Toulson*

Contrast

The poem contrasts different times and emotions.

Examples:

Past vs.

Childhood joy vs. adult grief

Eternal sea vs. short human life

QUESTION

What does the word 'cardboard' denote in the poem? Why has this word been used?

Answer:

The word 'cardboard' refers to the photograph's mount or frame. It has been used to signify an old photograph, perhaps brittle with age, that holds a memory from the past.

QUESTION

What has the camera captured?

Answer:

The camera has captured a moment from the past showing three girls, including the poet's mother, standing on a beach. The mother is in the middle, about twelve years old, enjoying a sea holiday with her cousins.

QUESTION

What has not changed over the years?

Answer:

The sea, which forms the background of the photograph, has not changed over the years. It remains the same while the people in the photograph have changed or passed away.

QUESTION

What does the poet mean by 'Both wry with the laboured ease of loss'?

Answer:

The poet and her mother both remember the loss — the mother remembered her childhood days with a mix of joy and sorrow, while the poet now remembers her mother with the same feeling after her death. "Laboured ease of loss" reflects the difficult process of coping with loss.

QUESTION

What does the last line of the poem suggest?

Answer:

The last line, “It’s silence silences,” suggests deep grief and mourning. The poet is so overwhelmed by the loss of her mother that she has no words left to express her sorrow — only silence remains.

QUESTION

How is the theme of loss presented in the poem 'A Photograph'?

Answer:

The poem deals with two layers of loss — the mother's loss of her childhood and the poet's loss of her mother. The photograph symbolizes memories and passing time. The sea remains unchanged while people age or die, showing the contrast between nature's permanence and human transience. The final silence points to the emotional void left after a loved one is gone.

QUESTION

Describe the tone of the poem.

Answer:

The tone is nostalgic, emotional, and somber. The poet reflects on the past fondly but also with a sense of sadness and acceptance. The use of phrases like “the big girl some twelve years or so,” and “now she’s been dead nearly as many years,” shows a quiet grief and maturity.

**Thank
You**